

American and British English: spelling

GRAMMAR

LEVEL
Intermediate

NUMBER
EN_BE_3907G

LANGUAGE
English

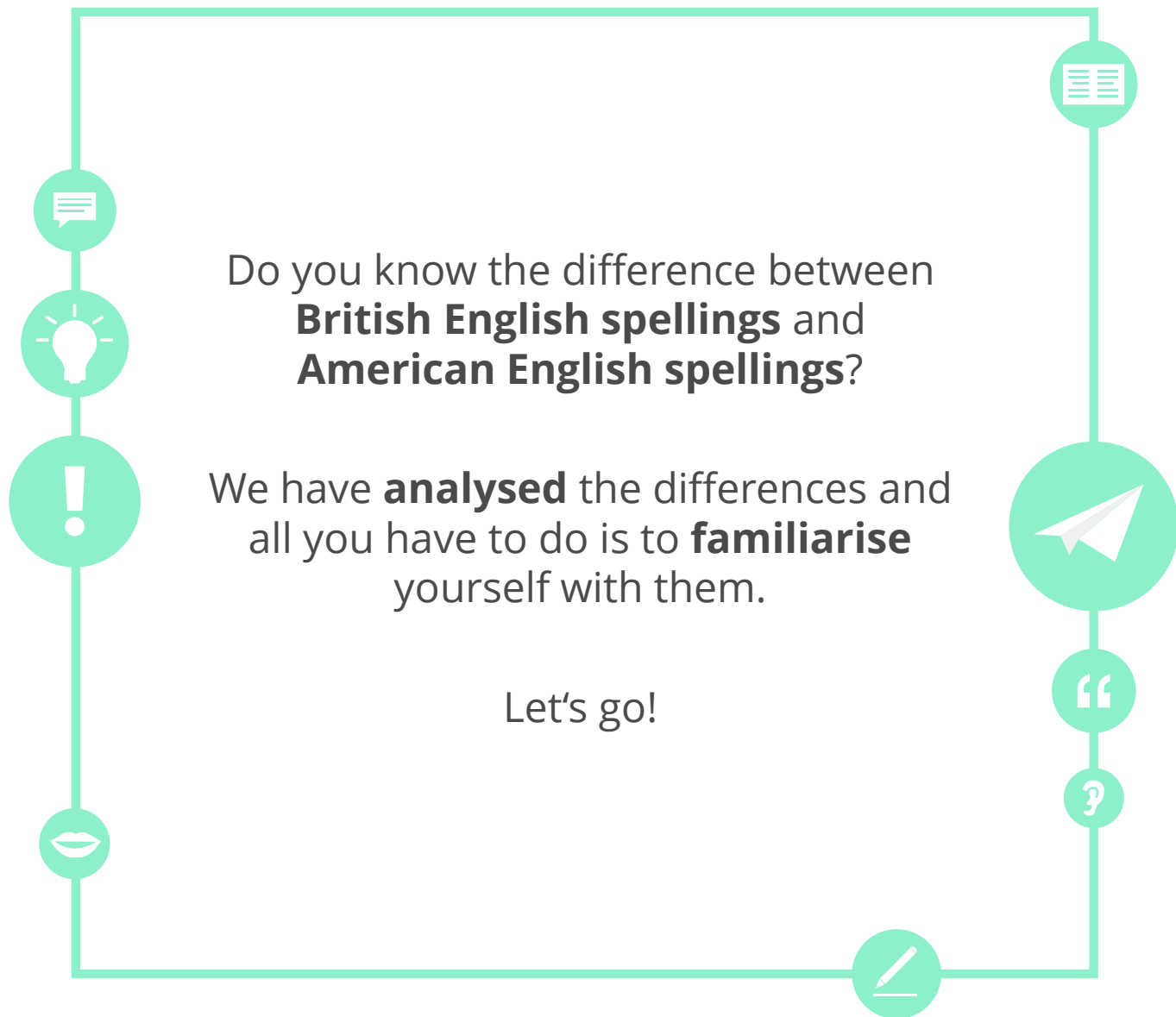




Goals

- Can identify some key differences in spelling between American and British English, using examples.
- Can apply this knowledge to spell a range of words accurately in both varieties.







Preview

- In this lesson, you will learn spelling differences between **American English** and **British English**.



When I was writing a letter to my **mum**, my classmate from America advised me to correct the spelling to **mom**.



Warm-up

1. Jessica feels ill because she ate too much.
2. Jessica feels ill because she's eaten too much.
3. Is Jose here? – No, he just left.
4. Is Jose here? – No, he's just left.
5. Can I see your project? – No, I didn't do it yet.
6. Can I see your project? – No, I haven't done it yet.

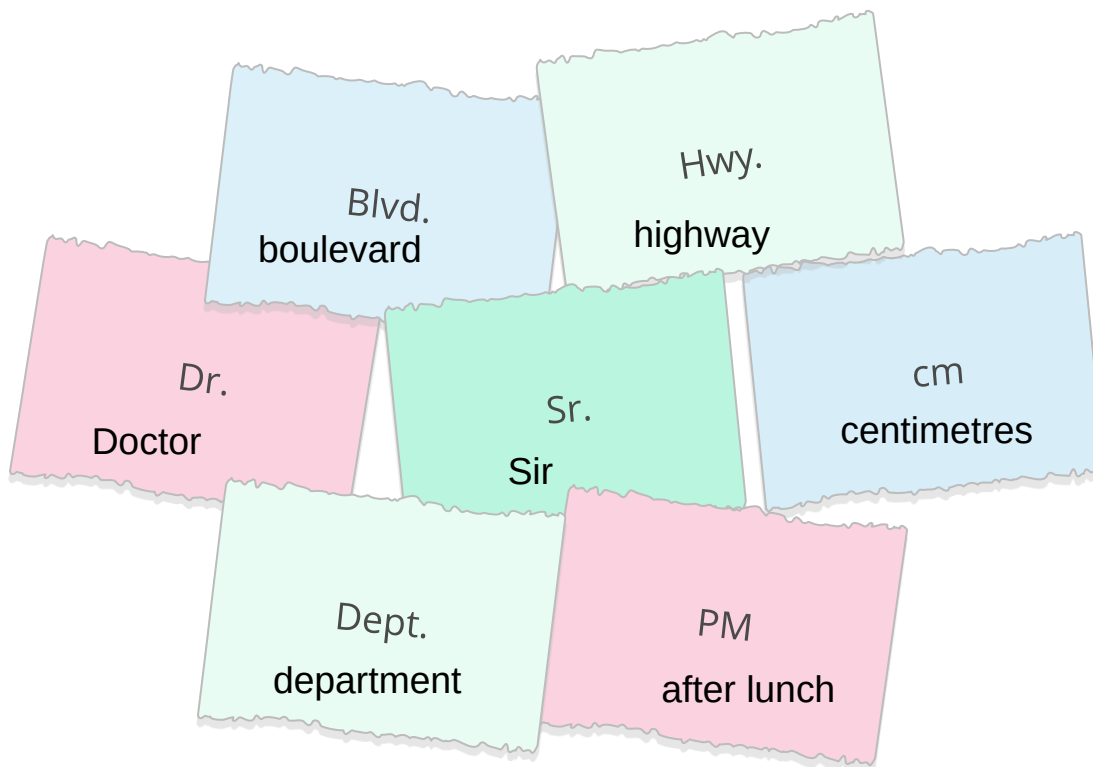
Can you tell the difference between British English and American English?



Abbreviation

An abbreviation is a shortened or contracted form of a word or phrase that is used to represent the whole.

Do you know what these abbreviations stand for?





BrE vs AmE

Depending on where you study English, your pronunciation, spelling and word choices can be different. BrE is an abbreviation for British English and AmE is for American English.

Read the sentences below and notice the difference.

British English
(BrE)



theatre

I went to the
theatre last
night.

BrE



American
English
(AmE)

theater

I went to the
theater last
night.

AmE





Different words

Do you know the difference between British English and American English words? Write down the different words that you know such as flat versus apartment.

British English

flat
the underground/
metro

American English

apartment



BrE vs AmE





Before you start

	BRITISH ENGLISH	AMERICAN ENGLISH
1. Colour <u>our</u> color(AmE)	☒	☐
2. Realize <u>ize</u>	☐	☒
3. Center	☐	☒
4. Catalogue catalog(AmE)	☒	☐
5. Apologise	☒	☐
6. Analyze	☐	☒



BrE vs AmE: *-our* vs *-or*

- In **British English**, words ending in **-our** are preferred while the **u** is dropped from the word in **American English**.

BrE: -our	AmE: -or	BrE: -our	AmE: -or
favourite	favorite	behaviour	behavior
harbour	harbor	neighbour	neighbor
labour	labor	honour	honor
humour	humor	flavour	flavor
rumour	rumor	colour	color



BrE vs AmE: *-ise(-yse)* vs *-ize(-yze)*

- **American English** uses the **-ize** spelling at the end of words while those same words are spelt with the **-ise** ending in **British English**.

BrE: -ise(-yse)	AmE: -ize(-yze)	BrE: -ise(-yse)	AmE: -ize(-yze)
to realise	to realize	to generalise	to generalize
to analyse	to analyze	to customise	to customize
to criticise	to criticize	to familiarise	to familiarize
to <u>utilise</u>	to utilize	to paralyse	to paralyze
to apologise	to apologize	to recognise	to recognize



BrE vs AmE: -ce vs -se

- While the **British** use the **-ce** ending nouns, **Americans** generally prefer **-se**.
- The spelling depends on whether the word **is a noun or a verb**.

BrE (-ce)	→	AmE (-se)
defence	→	defense
licence (n) license (v)	→	license (n, v)
offence	→	offense
pretence	→	pretense
practice (n) practise (v)	→	practice (n, v)



BrE vs AmE: -ogue vs -og

- **-ogue** can also be used in AmE, but **Americans** prefer the use of **-og**.

BrE (-ogue)	AmE (-og)
catalogue	catalog
demagogue	demagog
pedagogue	pedagog
analogue	analog
monologue	monolog



BrE vs AmE: ending in a vowel with *double l*

- **Americans** have dropped the *double l* when adding suffixes to verbs that end in the letter l.
- The **British** still use the *double l* approach to their spelling.

spelling(AmE and BrE)

BrE	AmE
travelling/traveller/travelled	traveling/traveler/traveled
fuelling/fuelled	fueling/fueled
cancelled	canceled
marriage counsellor	marriage counselor

helps married people with their emotional problems



BrE vs AmE: American English spellings with *double l*



- There is an exception to the rule in **American English**.
- These words are spelt with ***double l*** in **AmE** and not in **BrE**.

BrE	AmE
skilful	skillful
wilful	willful
to fulfil	to fulfill
instalment	installment
enrolment (to enrol)	enrollment (to enroll)



Always with a *single l*

While some significant differences exist between BrE and AmE spellings, the two variants also share plenty of spellings.

Can you think of any more?

welcome, almost, always

almighty

altogether

welfare

useful



Fill in the blanks and then practise using each word in a sentence.

Usually two people are duelling. The plane is spiralling from the sky.
This company distilled a very good whisky in the past.

BrE	AmE
1. duelling	1. <u>dueling</u>
2. tunnelled	2. <u>tunneled</u>
3. <u>spiralling</u>	3. spiraling
4. unrivalled	4. <u>unrivalled</u>
5. <u>woollen</u>	5. woolen
6. appal	6. <u>appall</u>
7. <u>enthrall</u>	7. enthrall
8. <u>distil</u>	8. distill



My grandpa
knitted me a lovely,
woollen scarf.



BrE vs AmE: *ae* and *oe* vs *e*

- The **British** retain more complex spelling of words with **Greek** or **Latin** roots, using the **orthodox spelling**.
- The **Americans** like their **terminology simplified**.

BrE (ae and oe)	AmE (e)
leukaemia bone marrow cancer	leukemia
manoeuvre how to move	maneuver
oestrogen the hormone, usually high in women	estrogen
paediatric doctor for children	pediatric



ae and *oe* vs *e*

Apply the rules from the previous slide on *ae* and *oe* vs *e* of BrE and AmE to write the British style of spellings of the words below.

1. eon Aeon

2. celiac coeliac coeliac: can't eat wheat

3. encyclopedia encyclopaedia

4. fetus foetus

5. homeopathy homoeopathy



BrE vs AmE: *-re* vs *-er*

- Words that end in **-re** in **British English** often have those letters **reversed** when spelt in **American English**.

BrE(-re)	AmE(-er)
centre	center
fibre optic fibre, in your diet it makes	fiber
theatre	theater
litre	liter
metre	meter



BrE vs AmE: *-re* vs *-er*



- Sometimes words also end in **-er** in BrE, too.
- See the examples below.

- chapter
- disaster
- filter
- enter
- letter
- member





Different spellings for different meanings

- Some words don't just have different spellings, but have a difference in meaning as well.

Words	BrE	AmE
dependant/dependent	Dependant is a noun while dependent is an adjective.	Only the -ent spelling.
programme/program	Program is generally only used to refer to computer programs.	Only program.
ensure/insure	Two clearly differentiated uses: to make sure vs to protect against something	Insure is taking over the use of ensure. Ensure is only used when there is a guarantee.



American English *drops the e*

- There are **three cases** when **Americans** will **drop an e** and the **British** will keep it.

Cases	BrE	AmE
1. verb + -ment	judgement	judgment
2. adjective with -able	sizeable	sizable
3. gerund	ageing	aging



How would Americans spell these words?

1. abridgement



2. acknowledgement



3. blameable



4. hireable



5. likeable





BrE vs AmE: miscellaneous words

There are some words that don't fit into the categories.
Compare and discuss how they are different.

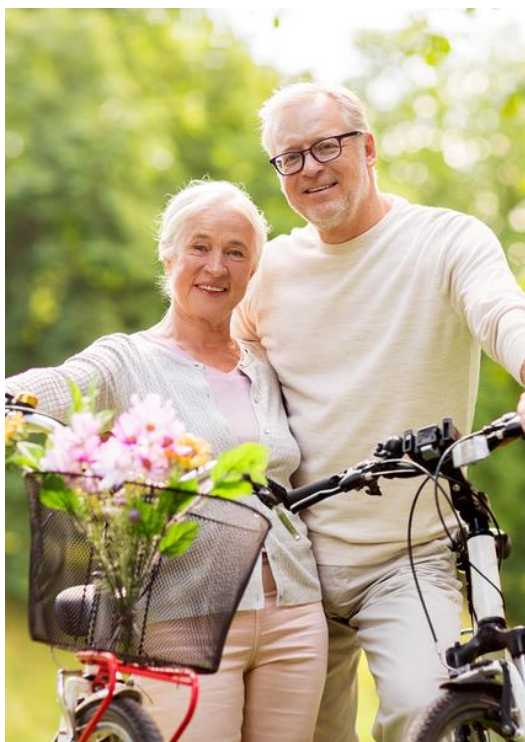
1. Carat (*BrE*) vs Karat (*AmE*)
2. Grey (*BrE*) vs Gray (*AmE*)
3. Mollusc (*BrE*) vs Mollusk (*AmE*)
4. Pyjamas (*BrE*) vs Pajamas (*AmE*)
5. Sceptic (*BrE*) vs Skeptic (*AmE*)
6. Tyre (*BrE*) vs Tire (*AmE*)





More exceptions

**These are some words that have more letters in British English, usually due to retainment of an original spelling from a foreign language.
How would Americans spell them?**



1. aeroplane

2. cheque

3. doughnut

4. draught

5. jewellery

6. omelette

7. plough

8. speciality

9. sulphur



Make your own sentences with these English spellings.

1. colonise



2. programme



3. humour



4. fulfil



5. quarrelling



6. symbolise



7. practise (verb)



8. litre





Quick fire round!



Without checking back on the previous slides, try to think of as many AmE and BrE spelling differences as you can.

When you have thought of a word, spell it out loud!

Dialogue is spelt d-i-a-l-o-g-u-e in British English and d-i-a-l-o-g in American English!



Reflect on the goals

Go back to the second slide of the lesson and check if you have achieved all the goals of the lesson.

yes

no





Reflect on this lesson

Think about everything you have seen in this lesson.
What were the most difficult activities or words? The easiest?



If you have time, go over
the most difficult slides again



Answer key

Activity p. 5

1, AmE, 2. BrE, 3. AmE, 4. BrE, 5. AmE, 6. BrE

Activity p. 9

1. A, 2. B, 3. B, 4. A, 5. A, 6. B

Activity p. 18

1. dueling, 2. funneled, 3. spiralling, 4. unrivaled, 5. woollen, 6. appall, 7. enthrall, 8. distill

Activity p. 20

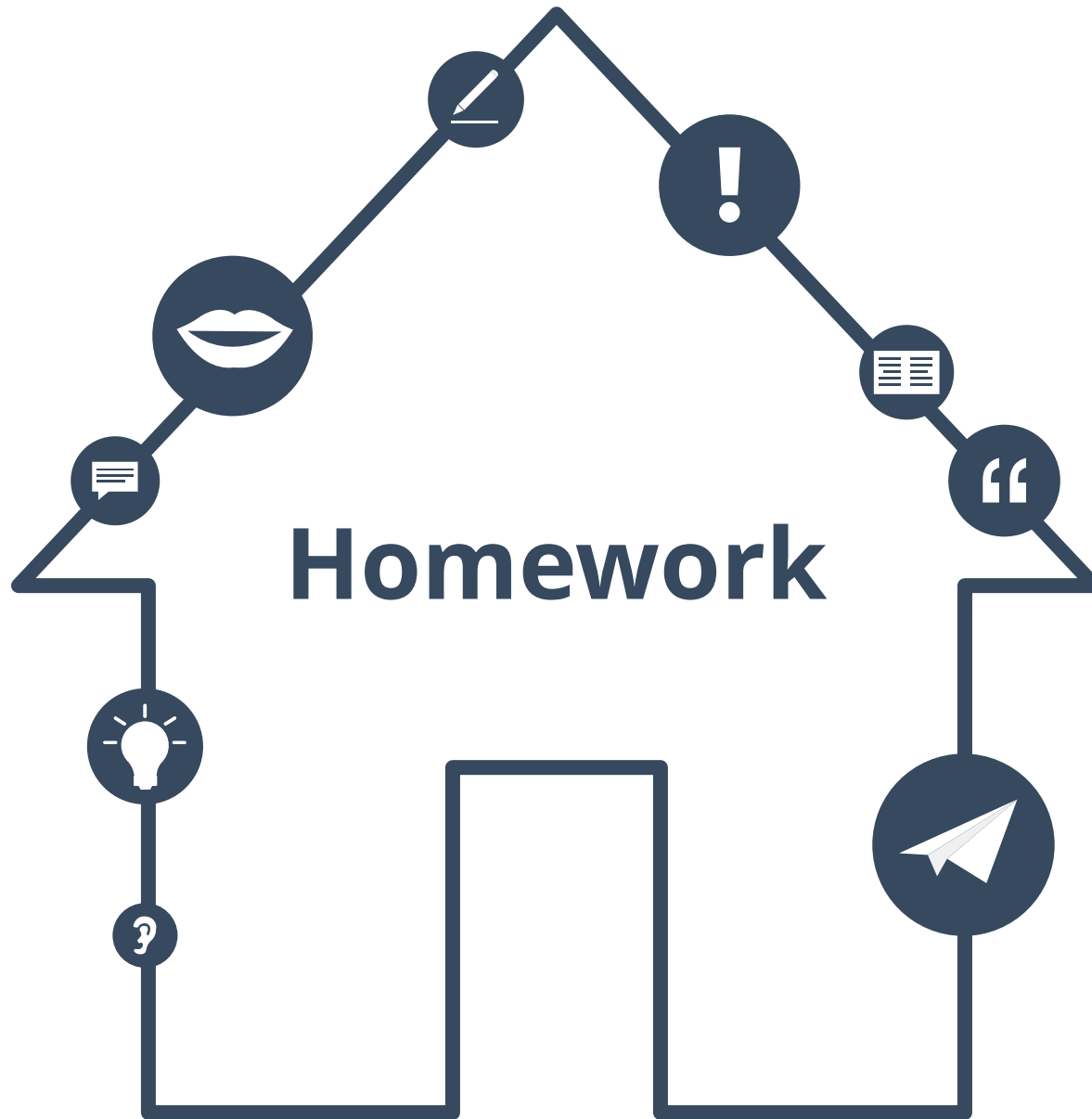
1. aeon, 2. coeliac, 3. encyclopaedia, 4. foetus, 5. homoeopathy

Activity p. 25

1. abridgment, 2. acknowledgment, 3. blamable, 4. hirable, 5. likable

Activity p. 27

1. airplane, 2. check, 3. donut, 4. draft, 5. jewelry, 6. omelet, 7. plow, 8. specialty, 9. sulfur





Homework: How do you spell these words in BrE?

1. Demeanor

a. _____

2. Odor

b. _____

3. Centimeter

c. _____

4. Somber

d. _____

5. Epilog

e. _____

6. Marvelous

f. _____

7. Appetizer

g. _____



Homework: writing activity

Do you think living in an urban city is better than living in a rural area? State your opinions supported by details and examples. Remember to use only British English spellings.

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Homework answer key

Activity p. 33

1. Demeanour, 2. odour, 3. centimètre, 4. somber, 5. epilogue, 6. marvellous, 7. appetiser



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